THE ROLE OF MICROFINANCE INSTITUTIONS IN REDUCING GENDER INEQUALITIES

Research Question: How effective are Microfinance Institutions in Reducing Gender Inequalities in Low-Income Countries?

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1. Introduction

1.1 Gender Inequality

Despite its population being roughly equal to men, women have always been seen as the minority. The effects of such inequality permeates into many aspects of society and every woman's life, from employment, education, to family relationships and much more. Women make up over two-thirds of illiterate people in the world, earn 77 cents for every dollar earned by men and make up less than 20% of the world's landholders (UN Women) .This global phenomenon is known as gender inequality, the discrimination on the basis of sex or gender (Save the Children).

1.2 Research Question and Purpose

The benefits of gender equality have been globally recognised, with achieving gender equality as one of the sustainable development goals set by the United Nations (SDGS UN). A study conducted by the International Monetary Foundation also states that higher gender equality supports economic growth (Bertay et al. 21), showing its importance to the development of a country. Gender equality is a fundamental human right and is crucial for a sustainable future. Therefore, there have been recent policy efforts towards reducing gender inequalities. This essay aims to explore microfinance institutions (MFIs) as a solution to reducing gender inequalities, answering the research question - **How effective are Microfinance Institutions in Reducing Gender Inequalities in Low-Income Countries?**

This research question is worthy of investigation because of its contemporary relevance to the world as gender inequality has been exacerbated due to the recent Covid-19 pandemic (Dang and

Nguyen 4-7) . Microfinance was chosen specifically as the centre of this research question amongst many other strategies due to its increase in popularity in the 21st century (Convergences) and its controversial nature. A focus on low income countries was also chosen as women in low income countries are more heavily affected by gender inequality.

1.3 Methodology

Using an interdisciplinary investigation with a combination of economics and geography, this paper will analyse the successes and drawbacks of MFIs. An economic perspective is used to study the choices of organisations when it comes to operating MFIs and the development of countries, drawing on economic theory such as the poverty trap and financial systems. Human geography is used to study the relationships between human development and gender inequality, utilising geographical concepts such as the spatial distributions of gender equality and human development and their indicators. Benefits of integrating economics and geography together in this paper is to spatialise economic concepts surrounding the provision of microfinance loans to women in low income countries, allowing for a more holistic discussion on the topic.

Two case studies of local manifestations of microfinance in Bangladesh and Pakistan will be used to see its real life applications and to compare and contrast its successes and failures. Bangladesh was chosen as it has one of the largest and oldest microfinance operations in the world, therefore the full potential of microfinance institutions impacting gender inequality could be seen through researching Bangladesh. Pakistan was chosen to offer a different perspective of microfinance operations as a country with a similar socio-economic status as Bangladesh following their footsteps in microfinance operations. The effectiveness of microfinance in both

countries will be discussed through reviewing research journals from economists who have conducted primary data collection or literature reviews on the impact of microfinance in Bangladesh and Pakistan. Government and bank documents are also used to analyse the way their institutes operate and the economic and social impacts it has on its female clients.

2. Gender Inequality in Low Income Countries

The extent of gender inequality can be measured using the Gender Inequality Index (GII), a composite measure developed by the United Nations Development Programme which takes into account reproductive health, empowerment, and labour market participation to quantify the level of gender disparity of a country (United Nations Development Programme). It is the newest and the most commonly used indicator of gender equality.

The GII has its limitations, its indicators used to quantify the level of gender inequality doesn't encompass the full extent of the issue, factors such as quality of life, domestic violence, ability to make decisions in the workplace and in the community are not taken into account. Therefore, when analysing the impacts of microfinance in the local manifestations later on in the paper, these additional indicators will be taken into consideration.

Gender Inequality Index

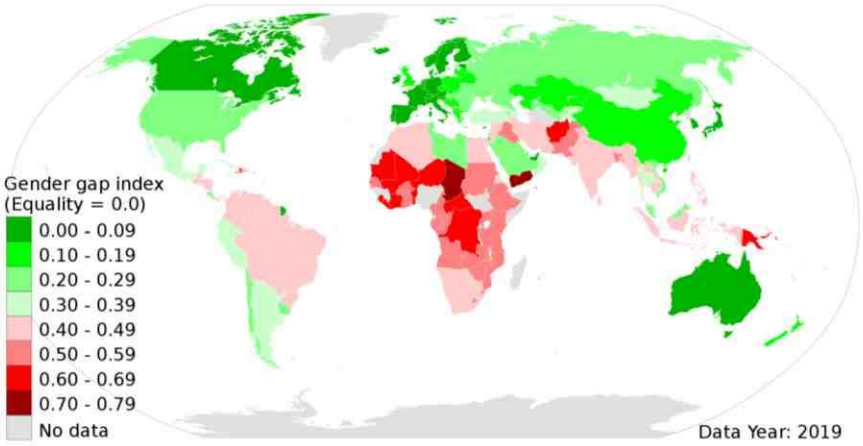


Figure 1: Countries by Gender Inequality Index in 2019 (Map from Wikipedia, Data from UNDP)

Even though gender inequality is a widespread global issue, Figure 1 shows that geographical disparities do exist. Africa and Western Asia is shown to be the most gender unequal with countries such as Yemen and Chad scoring the highest value in the GII. More developed countries such as Australia, Canada and western European countries are the most gender equal, showing that gender inequalities are larger in low income countries.

Low income countries struggle more with achieving gender equality due to underdevelopment, causing higher poverty levels compared to their high income counterparts (Oxfam). Poverty is caused by a variety of factors such as lack of education, low employment rates and lack of infrastructure development. Gender inequality is intrinsically linked with poverty, creating a vicious cycle known as the poverty trap. The poverty trap arises when low income households have low savings, causing low investments in capital, further causing a low productivity of

labour and land. This gives rise to low income growth and the cycle continues. The poverty cycle helps exacerbate gender inequalities as women are disproportionately affected by this. The effects of the poverty trap causes a lack of education access for women, meaning that they will not get the qualifications to find employment and be financially independent, causing gender inequalities in the labour market.

Women in low income countries are systematically excluded from the financial system, they are less likely to open up individual financial accounts and struggle to obtain credit due to lack of employment and education (Demricguc-Kunt et al. 28). Inheritance laws and lack of property rights for women in low income countries also means that they don't have much assets to offer as collateral if they want to take out a loan. This constraints economic opportunities available to women, resulting in the deepening of their economic and social deprivation.

3. How Microfinance Institutions Operate

Microfinance is a type of social enterprise which provides banking services to low-income individuals who otherwise would not have access to financial services. MFIs provide a variety of services such as small loans to poor entrepreneurs who lack access to credit, training to improve financial literacy, microinsurance and much more. Even though the concept of microfinance has roots dating back to the 18th century, it has only been recent years in which it gained popularity and international recognition when Muhammad Yunus won the Nobel Peace Prize for pioneering the microfinance industry through his work in the Grameen Bank back in 2006 (Investopedia).

MFIs operate differently from traditional banks. Applying for loans at traditional banking institutions requires an assessment of one's salary and assets to see whether they are capable of offering collateral, assets pledged by the borrower in order to protect the lender (Investopedia). However these eligibility criteria do not exist for microfinance loans as it targets those who are unable to meet these criteria in typical banking institutions. Because many applicants cannot offer collateral, MFIs tend to pool borrowers together in which they will repay their debts together. This is a common practice in MFIs in order to create pressure to ensure everyone's repayment of the loan.

There are different types of MFIs which differ in how microcredit services are provided. Development economist Jonathan Modurch categorises microfinance into two approaches, the welfarist approach and institutionalist approach. The welfarist approach includes MFIs that are supported under NGOs, they are typically of smaller scale and operate with a larger focus on achieving the social good by providing their services to those in abject poverty. Besides

providing loans, they also provide non-financial services such as training, technical assistance and literacy training. In contrast, the institutionalist approach includes MFIs that are supported by larger firms such as commercial banks. Unlike the welfarist approach, MFIs under the institutional approach targets those who are not as poor to help them start or expand their micro-enterprise with the motive of making profit from their clients (617-629). It is important to note such differences as they can have an impact on the effectiveness of MFIs as a whole.

4. Case Studies of Microfinance - Bangladesh

4.1 Bangladesh's Socio-Economic Background

Bangladesh is a country in South Asia. It is classified as a lower-middle income country by the World Bank and has a GDP per capita of 1,968.79 USD in 2020, ranking 167 out of 215 countries and territories recorded.

In 2019, Bangladesh had the GII value of 0.537, ranked 133 out of 162 countries calculated, a large increase compared to 2017 in which it was ranked 47 out of 144 countries, showing that gender inequality has decreased. In spite of recent improvements, gender inequalities still exists due to patriarchal ideals in Bangladeshi society, making it difficult for Bangladeshi women to not face discrimination in their day to day life.

Despite the fact that the demographic structure of Bangladesh shows that the sex ratio is 0.97 males to 1 female (IndexMundi), meaning that its population is roughly equal, inequalities on the basis of gender is still prevelant in Bangladeshi society. Lack of education access for females has caused disparities in literacy rates between males and females in Bangladesh, the male literacy rate is 76.67% while the female literacy rate is 71.18% (UNESCO). There are also disparities in nutrition levels, in which females are more prone to malnutrition compared to males (Global Nutrition Report). The female labour force participation rate in Bangladesh is 35% (World Bank), with 91.8% of females being involved in the informal sector relative to 82.1% for males. This shows that many women struggle with finding formal and stable employment.

Bangladeshi women's lack of opportunities can also be seen through its banking system.

Bank group-wise disbursement of loan to entrepreneurs in 2013

Group of Banks	Male		Female	
	Amount * 10 million Taka	%	Amount * 10 million Taka	%
SoCBS	5007.85	97.28	140.07	2.72
PCBS	70546.41	96.10	2865.48	3.90
SPBS	3522.31	95.45	168.05	4.55
FCBS	1145.04	96.46	42.00	3.54
Total	80221.61	96.15	3215.60	3.85

Figure 2: Distribution of loan disbursements between genders show that females are excluded from financial services (Data from SME & Special Programmes Department, BB)

The data from Figure 2 shows the amount of loan disbursement to male and female entrepreneurs sorted by different groups of banks - state-owned commercial banks (SoCBS), private commercial banks (PCBs), specialised banks (SPBs) and foreign banks (FCBs). The data shows a significantly larger proportion of loans disbursed to males compared to females, where male entrepreneurs obtained 96.15% of loans while their female counterparts only obtained 3.85% of loans disbursed. All four types of banks show a similar trend, indicating that this is a problem throughout the entire Bangladesh banking system. This trend shows that access to financial services is very unequal between males and females.

Overall, Bangladesh's cultural factors and lack of education access has created barriers for women in Bangladesh to access financial services, widening gender inequalities as they are unable to be financially independent.

4.2 Microfinance in Bangladesh

Microfinance has existed in Bangladesh for over 40 years, originating in 1976 when Muhammad Yunus founded the Grameen Bank as a development tool to alleviate poverty and promote entrepreneurship. As of 2014, over 700 MFIs have served over 33 million clients by providing them with both financial and non-financial services (Grameen Research).

Many MFIs in Bangladesh including the Grameen Bank focus on providing women with its services, with 97% of Grameen Bank's clientele being women. (Grameen Bank). This is because MFIs regard women to be more trustworthy borrowers and the income earned by female borrowers are seen to have more beneficial effects on the well-being of children and household members compared to their male counterparts (Bernasek 373).

4.3 Economic Impacts of Microfinance for Women

Several studies have shown that microfinance has a positive economic impact for women. Microfinance loans have increased the household incomes of women, lifting them out of poverty. Results from a 20 year longitudinal study concluded that microfinance accounted for a 10% reduction of rural poverty in Bangladesh, lifting 2.5 million Bangladeshi people out of poverty. For women in particular, microfinance loans have allowed them to increase their consumer expenditure as a result of the increased income (Khandker and Samad 29). An empirical study

examining Grameen Bank's impact on female borrowers supports a similar conclusion, with results showing that 57.5% of borrowers were no longer in poverty after one year, as opposed to only 18% of nonborrowers, observing that poverty rates of Grameen Bank borrowers are significantly lower compared to the nonborrowers (Todd). The prevalence of microfinance loans in rural villages of Bangladesh have also been shown to have 'significant spillover effects' (Karim 11) , with non-participants also profiting from the growth in productivity and welfare.

Despite microfinance's overall positive impacts on empowering women in Bangladesh, there are also problems in Bangladesh's microfinance industry that could potentially pose a risk to its sustainability in the future. Bangladesh's booming microfinance industry has led to intense competition among various MFIs, causing borrowers to have overlapping loans by borrowing from more than one institution. This can lead to a delay in payments of loans, potentially putting borrowers further in debt as a result of this (Yuge 6-7).

4.4 Social Impacts of Microfinance for Women

Studies regarding whether microfinance has benefited women socially have exhibited mixed results.

A study examined the level of social empowerment of female clients of microfinance institutions in Bangladesh by investigating their ability to make decisions and mobility through measuring their literacy and communication skills. The results of this study found that women do not feel more socially empowered as a result of being clients of microfinance institutions (Mustafa 187-192). Another study supported similar findings, explaining that the lack of social

empowerment is due to the increased workload for women from having to run a business on top of caring for their children and the households (Cheston and Kuhn, 42).

The lack of social empowerment can also be attributed to the way microfinance institutions operate in Bangladesh. There are a large range of microfinance institutions in Bangladesh ranging from ones that only offer financial services and those who provide social development services too. Microfinance organisations that are more focused on social mobilisation of women are found to have a larger impact on the social empowerment of women. However, some of the largest microfinance institutions with the largest clientele such as Grameen Bank and ASA primarily focus on offering financial services, leaving many women deprived of non-financial services such as training opportunities in leadership and entrepreneurship, family planning and disaster management (Kabeer et al. 45), limiting their social empowerment.

While some studies suggest that women do not benefit socially from being clients of microfinance institutions, there has also been evidence that women have benefited as a result from increased incomes. An empirical study suggests that educational and health expenses have increased amongst microfinance clients, indicating that some clients have experienced an increase of standard of living as a result of microfinance loans (Chowdhury et al. 69)

5. Case Studies of Microfinance - Pakistan

5.1 Pakistan's Socio-Economic Background

Pakistan is a country in South Asia with a similar socio-economic profile as Bangladesh. It has a GDP per capita of 1,193.73 USD and is considered to be a lower-middle income country by the World Bank.

Pakistan is ranked 99th out of 132 economics in the Gender Inequality Index, showing that gender inequality is a prevailing issue. Statistically this can be shown by the disparities between literacy rates of men and women, in which 47% of women are literate while 70% of males are literate. Issues such as gender based violence, lack of access to sexual and reproductive rights, domestic violence and discrimination further creates a barrier of development for Pakistan and female empowerment (UNFPA Pakistan).

5.2 Microfinance in Pakistan

In 2000, the first microfinance bank Khushali Bank was established in Pakistan. In the present, Pakistan has three different models of microfinance services that are currently operating. There are microfinance banks, microfinance institutions, and rural support programmes (Rauf 102). A study that analysed Pakistani MFI's outreach and performance have concluded that Pakistani MFIs are not productively using their assets and earning less returns compared to other South Asian MFIs such as Bangladesh (Mohsin et al. 33-34). Its inefficient operations can also be seen through its small outreach towards the poor in Pakistan, with 59% of microfinance clients being women, a significantly lower proportion of female clients compared to other countries such as

Bangladesh and India (Safavian and Haq 8) . A study has also shown that its outreach is less than 5% of the potential market of microfinance clients. The limited competition and small market size shows that microfinance isn't widespread in Pakistan and has yet achieved allocative efficiency (Ahmand 17).

5.3 Economic Impacts of Microfinance for Women

Economic impacts of microfinance for women in Pakistan are generally mixed. While some studies have reported that microfinance has helped increase the incomes of women, lifting them out of poverty (Niaz and Iqbal 10-11) , there has been no impact on the bargaining power and decision making abilities regarding decisions such as health, economic and social mobility from women who have received loans from microfinance institutions (Asim 55). This shows the lack of long-term impact in the empowerment of Pakistani women as a result of microfinance loans.

A study which examined the role of Pakistani microfinance institutions on poverty alleviation concluded similar findings, in which while microfinance programs have led to an increase in household expenditure, it had no positive impact on ownership of household assets (Noreen et al. 880). This reveals how Pakistan's microfinance only has positive short term impacts on women as they are able to increase expenditure after receiving the loan, but are unable to make significant impacts in decisions in owning assets and bargaining power in the long run.

Furthermore, the aforementioned problems with the lack of outreach and inefficient operations of microfinance in Pakistan has led to any potential positive economic impact of microfinance to be insignificant to the overall female population of Pakistan.

5.4 Social Impacts of Microfinance for Women

Women being involved in microfinance in Pakistan has shown to have negative impacts for them socially. Pakistan's patriarchal society in which men are regarded as the 'breadwinners' of the household has created negative impacts for Pakistani women when they gain more financial independence. Studies have shown that taking out microfinance loans have led to an increase in familiar tensions and domestic violence rates. This is due to the fact that women have been neglecting their expected household responsibilities and to focus on their businesses instead (Hasan 178-179) (Arshad et al. 2), limiting the positive impact of microfinance for women in Pakistan.

Several studies have also shown that many Pakistani women do not end up being the final users and beneficiaries of the microfinance loans. An estimated 50 to 70% of loans meant for female clients end up being used by their male relatives. Additionally, Pakistan's microfinance system prohibits women from taking out loans individually without requiring them to rely on their spouses or male relatives to act as guarantors in order to qualify for a loan (Safavian and Haq 7). This means that women are ultimately not the ones who use the loans, with many of their male relatives using loans for unsustainable purposes such as gambling. This also poses a problem for women such as windows and single mothers who do not have the resources to find male guarantors for their loans, leading to a further barrier from achieving social empowerment.

6. Analysis of Case Studies

By investigating the microfinance industry and its socio-economic impacts in Bangladesh and Pakistan, mixed results amongst many studies show that effectiveness of microfinance institutions in reducing gender inequality varies depending on a myriad of factors.

The way a microfinance institution operates has an impact on its effectiveness. In Pakistan, its inefficient operation due to financial problems has led to a smaller outreach in female clients compared to Bangladesh, leading its microfinance institutions to not have a significant impact on the empowerment of the Pakistani female population as a whole. Furthermore, the lack of regulation in Pakistan's microfinance operations has led to many cases in which the male relatives of the woman who took out the loan become the final user of the loan. Pakistan's microfinance loaning policies also make it difficult for women to take out a loan individually without relying on a male to approve the loan. Pakistan's inefficient operations and lack of regulation limit the extent of positive economic and social impact microfinance has on women.

In contrast, Bangladeshi women are found to be more economically empowered, caused by the increase in household incomes after becoming clients of microfinance institutions. Microfinance institutions have also led to women in Bangladesh to have increased savings and investments, giving them more flexibility and power on making decisions that would generally be made by men regarding investments, savings, participation in socio-economic activities etc.

However, this essay acknowledges that the evaluation of the impacts of microfinance in Bangladesh and Pakistan is limited to the published literature by different researchers regarding the topic. The research journals reviewed all had a different group of women they focused on to see the impacts, leading to a variation in results due to selection bias and use of different methodologies.

7. Conclusion

In conclusion, gender inequality is a growing global issue which severely impacts the economic and social development of low income countries. Women living in low income countries are disproportionately impacted by gender inequality which inhibits their ability to be financially independent. In the past few decades, microfinance has been implemented as a strategy to eradicate poverty for many low income countries. This essay aims to answer the question - 'How effective are Microfinance Institutions in Reducing Gender Inequalities in Low-Income Countries?'. It is beyond the scope of this study to comment on the impacts of microfinance on all low income countries, as this study focuses on Bangladesh and Pakistan using the research available regarding the work of microfinance institutions in those countries. Therefore the findings of this paper is not indicative of the effectiveness of microfinance in all low income countries. Nevertheless, the conclusions generated from this study can serve as an indication of the potential successes and drawbacks of microfinance institutions in low income countries with similar socio-economic backgrounds as Bangladesh and Pakistan.

On the surface, microfinance is seen as the panacea to help lift poor people out of poverty. But when further explored, the discussion surrounding microfinance appears to be much more nuanced with its many unintended side effects coming to light. Some studies suggest that microfinance has its benefits, it gives an opportunity to uplift women by providing them with financial services that they otherwise would not have access to. Microfinance can increase their household incomes, allowing women to be more financially independent and to give them the power to make decisions in their household and society. This can help uplift them from poverty and improve their quality of life.

However this paper has shown that such benefits are only contingent on whether women are able to use their microfinance loans effectively, which is not the case for many women in low income countries as a lack of education and cultural values continue to pose a barrier from reaping the benefits of taking out microfinance loans. This also shows the importance of non-financial services offered by microfinance institutions to help support women with their financial endeavours by providing them with training and support groups. Much of the systemic barriers that prevent women from being seen equal to men still exist regardless of microfinance's influence, with domestic violence rates increasing amongst female clients and some female clients not being the ultimate beneficiary of the loan. So even after women receive their microfinance loan, there are still hurdles that they will have to overcome in order to truly achieve empowerment.

Overall, although some benefits of microfinance can be seen, it has many issues and risks that threaten its sustainability and effectiveness in the long run. Many low income countries still have a long way to go before men and women are viewed as equals.

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